



Photographs by RAHJAN RAHI

**RABRI DEVI AS CHIEF MINISTER
AND LALU'S RULE BY PROXY
CREATED BAD BLOOD IN THE RJD**

his head, battling the invisible demons like a great bear beset by wasps, Lalu wants to banish the drubbing from his memory, though he clings on to its bitter taste that forces him to confront what they have done to his Bihar. It doesn't even feel like his Bihar anymore.

But he doesn't think it's over. The man who leapt out of his humble origins at Phulwaria village to script a staggering success story while milking opportunity out of every crisis has no cobwebs in his mind. "How strong my opponents are is not an issue. The question is how much the people have realised of Nitish Kumar's false promises," he says. Of late, he has taken the battle to the people—seeking empowerment from the very people he promises to empower. The man is ready to make amends, openly admitting mistakes laced with a sincere apology with an almost practised humility.

The man of the masses is back among them. His emotions, his sense of humour are intact. So is his sensitivity, a far cry from his highhandedness. He displays vulnerability perhaps to gain popular acceptance, or just to be a complete man. "I am like a guardian. I always was. Look at my age. If I ever chide anyone, it was only for good reasons," he says, trying to undo the bad memories of his bad-mouthing certain sections.

Most importantly, the candid Lalu appears willing to introspect. "We have made mistakes in the past. Our

partymen were arrogant and there was loads of bickering," he admits; and then quietly adds, "That was a time when many things went wrong. Wives of many politicians got inspired by Rabri Devi being chief minister. It kindled their ambition and rekin-

him. The Congress has already washed its hands off him with Rahul Gandhi declaring that the alliance with the RJD was a mistake. Arch rival Kumar is threatening to tear into his social base. The BJP is happily riding piggyback on the Lalu-undoer while friend and ally Ram Vilas Paswan, infamous for his overestimations, needs to get his act together.

Indeed, barring the September 2009 by-election results—which bolstered his spirits more than the real prospects—Lalu hardly has good electoral reason to cheer about since 2004. Today, he is out of power after 19 years of being in it. But he has never had an easy ride, not

since he first became chief minister in March 1990. Today, he knows he is chasing history as the chief minister's chair could be the solitary ticket to his revival and existence.

"My big brother (read Lalu) is eyeing the chief ministerial bungalow again. But I won't oblige him," Kumar quips. Even Lalu's old friends in the Congress are waiting to write his political epitaph. Their words taunt him like persistent whispers. Shaking

LALU HAS LEARNT
his lessons. The trouble is, so has Bihar. For many, he is still the axis of the revulsion wheel.

